



NORTHERN VERMONT YOUTH FOOTBALL LEAGUE

7/8 TACKLE RULES

League Year 2025

JUNE 2025

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1. INTRODUCTION AND SCOPE

The following rules and regulations govern play within the Northern Vermont Youth Football League (**NVYFL**). These rules are intended to supplement rules found in the National Federation of State High School Associations (NFHS) football rulebook in order to facilitate play at the Vermont youth level. All other rules shall be as identified in the NFHS rulebook.

These rules are not to be left for interpretation. Any questions regarding these rules must be highlighted to the Executive Committee for final determination. Failure to follow these rules will result in disciplinary action.

2. LEAGUE MISSION

The Northern Vermont Youth Football League's mission is to foster a program that is dedicated to providing a culture where student-athletes have the access to develop and compete in football through a fun, safe and nurturing environment. We will achieve this through:

- a. Providing a safe environment for players that supports skill development and learning through innovative pathways
- b. Fostering an environment that demonstrates respect to ones-self, teammates, opponents, officials, coaches and the diversity of our communities.
- c. Providing our coaches with tools, resources and the support they need with the guidance of USA Football to help develop the skills necessary for success
- d. Inspire and support a passion for football participation among players, coaches, families and communities

3. COACHES

The following is a list of requirements that must be completed and adhered to:

- a. **ALL** coaches, or volunteers, involved with teaching football to players **MUST** be certified through **USA Football** at the appropriate tackle / contact level.
 - i. Certifications **MUST** be included in League Books at the League Jamboree. Coaches that do not have certifications will not be allowed to participate in coaching until certifications are completed. Certifications completed after the League Jamboree, must be shared with the Executive Board for authorization to coach.
- b. **ALL** coaches, or volunteers, involved with the players must have background verifications. The Head Coach for each team / program is responsible for confirming these verifications are complete or in process, when they sign the League Roster.
- c. **ALL** coaches will be held to a high standard and level of expectation as they represent their players, staff, program, community and league. Any actions that misrepresent these key stakeholders will result in disciplinary action.
 - i. Communications must remain cordial and professional at all times.
 - ii. Coaches are viewed as leaders and mentors.

4. JAMBOREE REQUIREMENTS

ALL sanctioned NVYFL teams **MUST** comply with the following requirements. Teams that are not in compliance will be denied the opportunity to compete until all requirements are completed and reviewed by the Executive Committee.

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- a. **ALL** teams **MUST** maintain a minimum of 15 registered players throughout the season; players that quit are not considered registered.
- b. **ALL** teams **MUST** abide by NVYFL designated Player Pools. These pools are designed to allow border programs to have access to equitable community populations.
 - i. NVYFL Player Pools **DO NOT** include areas outside Vermont state borders.
 - ii. Players **MUST** play for the team that represents their residency. Player Waivers may be submitted / completed to allow players to play for different teams but, these waivers **MUST** be agreed upon by the two program representatives, presented to the Executive Committee for review and approval, and included in the League Book at the Jamboree.
- c. **ALL** teams **MUST** have a complete League Book to present to the Executive Committee at the time of their scheduled player weigh-in. Non-compliance to the following requirements listed will result in review and disciplinary actions imposed by the Executive Committee:
 - i. Official NVYFL Player Registration Form; signed by parent or guardian. Players without a signed Player Registration Form may not participate in any League sanctioned activity; practices, games, etc.
 - ii. Copy of Player Birth Certificate
 - iii. Official Team Roster organized in numerical order by jersey number; signed and sanctioned by team Head Coach
 - 1. Players must be assigned appropriate jersey numbers for their positions; numbers are assigned based on offensive positions:
 - a. Quarterbacks, Running Backs and Wide Receivers: 1 - 49, 80 - 89
 - b. Tight Ends: 80 - 99
 - c. Linemen: 50 - 79
 - i. If an offensive lineman does not have the appropriate jersey number, they will be asked to leave the field, and the Head Coach will receive a warning. This can be resolved by providing the player with an appropriately numbered jersey, or placing a practice pinny over their jersey.
 - ii. If the player returns to the field without resolution, they will be asked to leave the field and the Head Coach will receive a personal foul and the team will be assessed a 15 yard penalty.
 - iv. **ALL** Coaches' USA Football Certifications
 - v. Player Waivers
- d. **ALL** teams **MUST** complete player weigh-ins for skill position verification. Players must be within the following position weight limits:
 - i. Quarterback, Running Back and Wide Receiver: Maximum **138 lbs**
 - ii. Tight Ends: Maximum **145 lbs**
 - 1. **NOTE:** A player will qualify for their skill position so long as their weight does not show as the "next full pound". Example: A player at 138.9 lbs qualifies for quarterback, running back or wide receiver.

5. PLAYER ELIGIBILITY AND REQUIREMENTS

- a. A player **CAN NOT** be above 8th grade, or above the age of 14 before the end of the season (Championship Game - First Saturday of November).
 - i. Confirmation of age eligibility will be with the players birth certificate; included in the League Book, and reviewed at the League Jamboree.

- ii. If a birth certificate is not available at the League Jamboree, the player is not eligible to participate until one is obtained and verified by the Executive Committee. The certificate will then need to be added to the League Book and reviewed at each game with the opposing coach.
 - iii. If an ineligible player plays or practices, the coach will be subject to disciplinary actions, with potential to escalate to program disciplinary actions if not resolved.
- b. A player may move to the 5 / 6 tackle level **ONLY** if the following criteria are met:
 - i. The player must be in their first year of tackle football; they can not have participated in any organized or sanctioned tackle program, regardless of previous residency.
 - ii. The player **CAN NOT** be 12 years old before the end of the season (Championship Game - First Saturday of November)
 - iii. A written request must be submitted to the Executive Committee for review and approval, **BEFORE** the player can change level.
 - iv. If approved, the player must comply with all rules and expectations of the 5 / 6 Tackle level. It is also "good faith" to communicate the player's circumstance with the opposing coaches.
- c. ALL players are required to exemplify safety, good sportsmanship, and respect for the game, opponents, coaches, officials and fans.
 - i. Unsportsmanlike actions will not be tolerated by anyone. Unsportsmanlike fouls will result in the player's ejection from the game and will be assessed a 1 game suspension for the following game; this also applies if the following game is a play-off game.
 - ii. Unsportsmanlike fouls will be reported to the Executive Committee immediately following the game.

6. OFF SEASON WORKOUTS AND FOOTBALL CAMPS

No team shall participate in any non-sanctioned football camp, or event, by the NVYFL. This includes any Summer Flag league. Players participating in NVYFL sanctioned camps are authorized to participate as the camp is designed. Summer workouts or non-sanctioned camps are only to support player conditioning, agility or position drills; no offensive or defensive plays may be instructed or practiced.

7. GAME DAY AND PLAYING FIELD

- a. **Game Logistics**
 - i. 7 / 8 games are scheduled to begin (kick-off) at **9:00 a.m.**
 - ii. Coaches should communicate / coordinate with each other regarding game locations and start times.
 - iii. Any change to location or start times must be shared with the Executive Committee to ensure timely scheduling of officials.
 - iv. The **HOME** team is responsible for identifying and providing volunteers to run the field chains. This group is considered part of the officiating crew and must act accordingly. Inappropriate interactions with the visiting team, coaching from the sideline, arguing with officials or any other actions deemed unsportsmanlike, will result in their removal from the game. Additionally, the visiting team is required to treat these volunteers as members of the officiating crew and treat them accordingly. Inappropriate treatment or interactions with the volunteers will result in removal from the field and game; additional disciplinary actions may result with a review from the Executive Committee.
- b. **Medical Personnel**

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- i. Medical personnel are **REQUIRED** at **EVERY NVYFL** tackle football game, and is the responsibility of the **HOME** team to coordinate coverage. A qualified "medic" may be the following: Registered Nurse, Physician, EMT or authorized trainer.
 - 1. The medical personnel should be identified and introduced to both coaches and officials before the coin flip of the game. The game is not authorized to begin without an identified medical staff member.
 - 2. Medical personnel should be immediately accessible in case of an emergency. It is recommended this person remains on a sideline, and is visible, by coaches and officials.
 - 3. If the Medical personnel is required to leave the game, a back-up must be identified; coaches and officials should discuss a coverage plan to allow the game to proceed safely.
- c. **Field Requirements**
 - i. The playing field will be 80 yards, with 2 10-yard end zones. The field width should be regulation of 53.3 yards, but if conditions do not allow it, the field must be a minimum of 40 yards wide.
 - ii. A Safety Zone must be identified along each sideline of the football field; cones, paint, ribbon, etc. It is also suggested to use yard markers to identify this safety zone. The minimum Safety Zone is 5 yards. This zone is to ensure safe operation and travel for the game officials and chain gang.
 - iii. Spectators are NOT permitted behind the end zones or sidelines. There must be a designated area for spectators to safely enjoy the game. Inappropriate interaction from spectators should be shared with the Executive Committee immediately following the game. Officials are authorized to warn, penalize or remove spectators for inappropriate actions. In any case, the official will stop the game and issue a warning to the team's head coach. If actions continue, a delay of game penalty will be issued against the spectator's team. If actions continue, an additional penalty will be enforced and the spectator will be asked to leave the game and property.
 - iv. One coach is authorized to walk between 10-yard lines, outside the safety zone. All other coaches and players must remain between outside the safety zone, and between the 20-yard markers.
- d. **Game**
 - i. Each team will provide their own football for game play. Officials will switch the footballs as required. The football material is not limited, but it must be **YOUTH** size only. Each team **MUST** show their footballs to the officials before the game begins, for their approval.
 - ii. The game will consist of 4 ten minute quarters, with stop times according to NFHS rules; Teams will switch end zones at the beginning of each quarter.
 - iii. There will be 2-minute intermissions between quarters, with a 10-minute halftime.
 - iv. Each team will be provided **3 timeouts per half**. A maximum of 3 coaches may be on the field during each timeout. In the case of an injury timeout, coaches are prohibited from coaching their players. The players will be requested to move away from the injured player; the coach may remain with their team during the injury-time and provide players with water. Players can not leave the field.
 - v. The use of radios, cell phones or any communication device is prohibited.
 - vi. Communications with the officials may only be with the Head Coach.
 - vii. Coaching must occur on the sidelines only, by certified and authorized coaches. Communication from the stands or spectator areas is prohibited.
 - viii. Coaches or opposing team staff are prohibited from team sidelines.
- e. **Scoring**
 - i. Touchdowns: 6 points
 - ii. Extra Points: may be scored by running or completed pass
 - 1. 1-Point: 2.5 yard line
 - 2. 2-Points: 5-yard line
 - 3. 3-Points: 10-yard line
- f. **Overtime:** Game tied at the end of regulation play, the following procedure will be used to resolve the tie:
 - i. A coin toss will determine possession and end zone.
 - ii. Each team will receive one possession, starting from the 10-yard line; the game clock is not required, but officials will observe a play clock.

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- iii. Each team will have 1 timeout per overtime
- iv. Possession will end when a team scores or loses possession on downs or turnover. A team can score on a turnover (fumble or interception return).
- v. Scoring will be the same as Regulation.
- vi. If the score remains tied after the first overtime, a second overtime will be played. All overtime rules will be applied; initial possession will be switched from the first overtime.
- vii. If the score remains tied after the second overtime, the game will conclude and designated a tie.

8. SCOUTING

Scouting of other teams is permitted, but the use of any recording devices during those games is prohibited. Teams are authorized to record games they are competing in. Failure to comply with this requirement will result in disciplinary actions from the Executive Committee.

9. INJURIES

- a. Injured players that require an official's time out must leave the game for a minimum of two plays. If the injury is to the head or neck the player may not return to the game without medical approval.
- b. Any injury during practice or game situations that results in the injured player missing a subsequent game must be reported to the Executive Committee within 48 hours, and a **Player Injury Form** completed within 1 week. Coaches should consider calling the league President or Vice President to make them aware of the incident and subsequent injury.

10. DIVISIONS

The league shall be divided into two divisions. League membership will discuss the divisions during the off-season to verify alignment and competitive schedule. Considerations must be taken for program location and travel while working through divisional alignment and scheduling.

11. PENALTIES

- a. Typical 15-yard penalties per the NFHS rulebook shall be assessed at 10 yards, except for:
 - i. Unsportsmanlike conduct penalties will be assessed at 15 yards. A second occurrence on the same player, or coach, will result in a second 15-yard penalty, game ejection, and next game suspension.
- b. Violation of league rules during a game after the play has begun is a 15 yard penalty.
- c. Any player on the field not equipped with a mouth guard will receive a warning, and be requested to leave the field. A second infraction, the player will be requested to leave the field, and a 5-yard penalty assessed against the team. A third infraction, the player will be ejected from the game and the team will be assessed a 15-yard penalty.
- d. The penalty for roughing the passer shall be 10 yards from the line of scrimmage or the end of the resulting run.

12. PLAYER WEIGHT LIMITS

- a. All offensive backs, receivers and quarterbacks have a maximum weight of **138 lbs**. These position players may take handoffs, pitches, screen passes and laterals behind the line of scrimmage.

- b. Tight Ends may not weigh more than **145 lbs**. A Tight End is eligible to receive the ball only by a forward pass across the line of the scrimmage.
- c. All players that may potentially be offensive ball carriers must weigh in at the season-start jamboree, or as directed by the League Board (in special circumstances). If a player does not weigh in by this time, or is over the designated weight for their position, then they are ineligible to play these positions during the season.
- d. If a weight challenge is made concerning the same player by two or more coaches from different teams, then the Executive Committee will convene to decide if the player must be re-weighed. If the decision is made to re-weigh the player, then the player must be weighed before their next game. If the player is more than 5 pounds over the limit, then the player is immediately disqualified from any ball-carrying position for the remainder of the season.
- e. Any player, regardless of weight, may recover and advance a fumble, or interception, that the NFHS rulebook allows. However, the player that intercepted, or picked up the fumble, can not lateral to an "overweight" player.
- f. A Tight End weighing over 138 lbs and under 145 lbs must line up on the line of scrimmage and within one arm's length of the last offensive lineman. A player within the Tight End weight range can not be in another offensive skill position, or be put in motion prior to the snap of the ball.

13. OFFENSE

- a. All players must wear a mouthguard.
- b. Players must be assigned appropriate jersey numbers for their positions; numbers are assigned based on offensive positions:
 - i. Quarterbacks, Running Backs and Wide Receivers: 1 - 49, 80 - 89
 - ii. Tight Ends: 80 - 99
 - iii. Linemen: 50 - 79
- c. If an offensive lineman does not have the appropriate jersey number, they will be asked to leave the field, and the Head Coach will receive a warning. This can be resolved by providing the player with an appropriately numbered jersey, or placing a practice pinny over their jersey.
- d. If the player returns to the field without resolution, they will be asked to leave the field and the Head Coach will receive a personal foul and the team will be assessed a 15 yard penalty.
- e. Formations
 - i. All offensive linemen must be within one arm's length of each other, including Tight Ends.
 - 1. Players that qualify for Tight End weight, and are above the Ball Carrier weight, **MUST** be on the Line Of Scrimmage, within 1 arm's length of the last down linemen.
 - 2. Tight Ends **CAN NOT** be set in motion
 - 3. Players that qualify for Tight End weight, and are above the Ball Carrier weight, **CAN NOT** take a handoff, lateral or pitch, or screen pass behind the line of scrimmage.
 - ii. The center's head may extend into the neutral zone, but not beyond the furthest point of the ball.
- f. Blocking
 - i. Blocking below the waist is **PROHIBITED**
 - ii. Leading with the head or face mask is **PROHIBITED**; Butt Blocking is prohibited.
- g. Play Clock
 - i. Offenses will be afforded a 40 second play clock. Failure to snap the ball within 40 seconds will result in a delay of game penalty.

14. DEFENSE

- a. All players must wear a mouthguard.

- b. Defensive players may not charge the line faking a blitz for the purpose of causing the offense to move.
Penalty: Warning for the first time, five yards thereafter.
- c. Face Tackling is prohibited

15. SPECIAL TEAMS

a. Punts and Punt Returns

- i. The Kicking Team must comply with all position weight limits; ball carrier, wide-outs and tight ends.
 - ii. **Fake Punts:** The punter **MUST** be ball carrier weight in order to fake a punt; pass or run. If the Kicking Team has an overweight punter, the ball must be kicked.
 - iii. The Return Team may not cover or engage the long-snapper; a player can not line up over the center, or initiate any contact with the center.
 - iv. The Return Team may not overload or overwhelm the offensive line. The Defense may not have more than 6 players on the line of scrimmage during a punt.
 - v. The Return Team **CAN NOT** blitz the punter; the 6 players may rush or pursue the kicker.
 - 1. If the punter rolls out beyond the area of the offensive tackles, it will be assumed to be a fake punt (run or pass); the defensive backfield (linebackers, corners, etc.) may pursue the player.
 - vi. The Return Team must comply with all position weight limits; ball carrier, wide-outs and tight ends.
 - 1. Players that are ball carrier weight may return / advance the football. If any player that is not ball carrier weight possesses the football, the play will be whistled dead and the offense will take over at that spot.
- b. **Kickoff:** The NAVYFL has decided to reinstate live kickoffs and kickoff returns. Given the focus on player safety and evaluations of different approaches to this phase of the football game, we will be implementing the format of the Dynamic Kickoff.
- i. **Kicking Team Formation:**
 - 1. Five players **MUST** be positioned on each side of the kicker at the time of the kick.
 - 2. **ALL** non-kicking players must line up with at least one foot touching the 35-yard line and cannot move until the ball is kicked.
 - 3. **NO** player, except the kicker, may have a running start before the ball is kicked.
 - ii. **Kickoff Process:**
 - 1. The ball will be kicked from the 35-yard line
 - 2. **NO** on-side kicks
 - 3. The kicking team **MUST** clear the receiving team's 25-yard line.
 - a. If the ball does not clear the 25-yard line, the kicking team will have a second chance
 - b. If the ball does not clear the 25-yard line a second time, the ball will be placed on the Receiving team's 30-yard line.
 - 4. If the ball is kicked out of bounds
 - a. The receiving team can take the ball at the point it went out of bounds, or
 - b. The receiving team can have the ball re-kicked.
 - i. If the ball goes out of bounds, the ball will be placed at the 30 yard line.
 - ii. If the ball does not clear the 25-yard line, it will be considered a second failed attempt and the ball will be placed at the 30-yard line.
 - iii. **Kick Return:**
 - 1. A minimum of eight players must line up on the 35-yard line of the receiving team and must have at least one foot touching the 35-yard line. These players **CAN NOT** move until the ball has been kicked.

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2. The remaining players must be positioned inside the 20-yard zone of the receiving team (between their 20-yard and goal lines).
 3. Returners must be Ball Carrier weight.
 4. A Fair Catch will be placed at the point of the catch
 5. The ball **MUST** be advanced by a player within the ball carrier weight, except in the case of a fumble recovery by an ineligible player.
- iv. **Touchbacks:**
1. Any kick that lands in the end zone without being touched by the receiving team will be an automatic touchback, with possession starting at the **20-yard line**.
 2. If the receiving team fields the ball in the end zone and elects not to return it, the ball is also placed at the **20-yard line**.
- v. **Blocking and Contact Rules**
- a. Wedge blocking (two or more players forming a blocking wall) is prohibited and will result in a 15-yard penalty from the spot of the foul.
 - b. Blindside blocks and blocks above the shoulders are illegal and will result in a 15-yard penalty.
 - c. All blocks must be initiated within the field of vision of the opposing player.
 - d. Players must remain under control when engaging in blocks, focusing on safe contact techniques. Any flagrant personal fouls, or dangerous hits will result in a 15-yard penalty and potential ejection depending on severity.